

PHILOSOPHY PAPER II - PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION 01 - NOTIONS OF GOD

ONE CONTINUOUS AT-A-GLANCE MASTER FLOW | CONCEPTUAL GRAMMAR -> WESTERN MODELS -> ATTRIBUTES -> SPINOZA -> ADVAITA -> RAMANUJA -> INDIAN PARITY -> COMPARISON -> OBJECTIONS -> PYQ ROUTING

Read the cyan rail from Stage 01 to Stage 10. Core doctrine is complete before the PYQ and answer-writing enrichment. Each stage uses a topic-specific visual grammar rather than a repeated card template.

CYAN: PRIMARY DOCTRINE / CONTINUOUS RAIL AMBER: EXACT TERM / DISTINCTION TEAL: MECHANISM / RELATION RED: OBJECTION / TRAP MAGENTA: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

SOURCE CONTROL CANONICAL OWNERS: Notions-of-God.md + Uncompressed Complete Learning Session + Solved Practice Workbook (all dated/identified in design-spec.json)

APPROVAL: FALSE - NEW G6 GENERATION - USER REVIEW PENDING

CORE FIRST | PYQ ENRICHMENT LAST

01

STAGE 01 CONCEPTUAL GRAMMAR - TWO INDEPENDENT AXES, THEN LANGUAGE CONTROL

PERSONAL != BODILY IMPERSONAL != INERT TRANSCENDENT != SPATIALLY FAR IMMANENT != IDENTICAL CATAPHATIC = AFFIRM APOPHATIC = REMOVE LIMITS

2 x 2 AXES - ANALYTICAL PLACEMENTS, NOT COMPLETE DEFINITIONS

PERSONAL + TRANSCENDENT

Classical theism

Intellect, will and love; creator distinct from, yet sustaining, the world.

PERSONAL + IMMANENT

Ramanuja / antaryamin

Supreme person indwells selves and world as controller while exceeding them.

IMPERSONAL + IMMANENT

Spinoza

One infinite substance; finite minds and bodies exist as dependent modes.

IMPERSONAL + TRANSCENDENT

Advaita Nirguna Brahman

Absolute beyond limiting predicates; not a deliberating person among persons.

TWO SPECTRA

PERSONAL

TRANSPERSONAL

IMPERSONAL

Personality axis: agency and relation, not a physical body.

TRANSCENDENT

BOTH

IMMANENT

World-position axis: ontological independence and/or sustaining presence.

CLOSE-OPTION REPAIR

- Personal: intellect, will and purposive relation - never a finite human body.
- Impersonal: not a deliberating person - never inert matter by definition.
- Transcendence: ontological independence - never spatial distance.
- Immanence: presence, sustaining or indwelling - never automatic identity.

CATAPHATIC

Affirms good, wise, powerful and loving. Positive predicates supply religious content.

APOPHATIC

Denies finite, composite and dependent modes of predication: neti neti.

CONTROL RULE

Affirm perfection analogically; deny creaturely limitation. Too much affirmation anthropomorphizes; too much denial empties God-talk.

TRAP

A notion of God is a metaphysical profile: referent + attributes + world relation + human relation + religious function. A first cause is not automatically personal, omniscient, good or worship-worthy.

ANSWER LINE

Personal/impersonal describes the mode of ultimacy; transcendent/immanent describes its relation to the world. The axes must never be collapsed.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> WESTERN MODEL FAMILY - FIVE DECISIVE GOD-WORLD-HUMAN RELATIONS

02

STAGE 02 WESTERN MODEL FAMILY - FIVE DECISIVE GOD-WORLD-HUMAN RELATIONS

THEISM = CREATES + SUSTAINS DEISM = CREATES + WITHDRAWS PANTHEISM = IDENTITY PANENTHEISM = WORLD IN GOD PROCESS = DIPOLAR RELATION BEFORE LABEL

CLASSICAL THEISM

GOD != WORLD



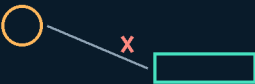
WORLD

Creates ex nihilo and continuously sustains a distinct contingent world.

HUMAN

DEISM

CREATOR -> LAWS -> AUTONOMY



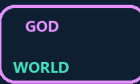
WORLD

An intelligent creator institutes natural laws, then rejects special intervention.

HUMAN

PANTHEISM

GOD = NATURE



WORLD

No external creation; reality exists in the one divine whole.

HUMAN

PANENTHEISM

WORLD IN GOD; GOD > WORLD



WORLD

The world exists in God, but God is not exhausted by the world.

HUMAN

PROCESS / DIPOLAR

PRIMORDIAL + CONSEQUENT POLES



WORLD

God orders possibilities and receives the world's becoming; relation is dynamic.

HUMAN

SIMPLICITY vs MANY ATTRIBUTES

How can one simple reality be power, knowledge and goodness?

Predicates differ in our concepts but signify one divine reality.

Modal collapse and property-identity objections remain.

1. God infallibly knows at t1 that S does A at t2.

2. The past and infallibility appear fixed.

3. Therefore S cannot do otherwise at t2.

4. A compatibilist denies that alternative possibilities are required; a libertarian must deny or revise a premise.

TRAP

Freedom and omnipotence are not direct contradictories. Distinguish possessing power from constantly exercising exhaustive control, then state which foreknowledge premise your solution rejects.

ANSWER LINE

The God-concept is a package of mutually constrained perfections; coherence is earned only after power, knowledge, goodness, time, change and simplicity are specified.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> SPINOZA - DEUS SIVE NATURA INSIDE THE METAPHYSICS OF SUBSTANCE

04

STAGE 04

SPINOZA - DEUS SIVE NATURA INSIDE THE METAPHYSICS OF SUBSTANCE

DEUS SIVE NATURA

ONE INFINITE SUBSTANCE

IN ITSELF / CONCEIVED THROUGH ITSELF

INFINITE ATTRIBUTES

THOUGHT + EXTENSION

FINITE MODES

IMPERSONAL IMMANENCE

NECESSITY

GOD OR NATURE - ONE INFINITE SUBSTANCE

self-caused (causa sui); ontologically and conceptually independent

ATTRIBUTE: THOUGHT

The intellect perceives the essence of substance as thinking reality.

FINITE MODES: ideas and minds

ATTRIBUTE: EXTENSION

The intellect perceives the same essence as extended reality.

FINITE MODES: bodies and motions

SUBSTANCE TREE RULE

God has infinitely many attributes; humans know Thought and Extension. Attributes are not separable parts and modes are not independent substances.

NATURA NATURANS

Nature naturing: God/Nature as active, infinite, self-caused substance.

NECESSARY EXPRESSION

No free first decision to create; the modal order follows eternally from divine nature.

NATURA NATURATA

Nature natured: the complete dependent order of modes.

OBJECTION: PERSONALITY

No deliberating will, providence, command or reciprocal prayer.

REPLY: person-like will would finitely anthropomorphize the infinite.

OBJECTION: FREEDOM

Necessity seems to destroy alternative choice.

REPLY: freedom is action from one's own nature without external constraint.

OBJECTION: PANTHEISTIC COLLAPSE

Calling each finite object 'God' confuses a mode with the whole substance.

REPLY: finite things are in God as dependent modes; God is not their aggregate.

TRAP

Spinoza's Nature is not merely physical matter. Deus sive Natura states identity, while the substance-attribute-mode architecture explains that identity.

ANSWER LINE

Spinoza replaces the transcendent personal creator with an impersonal, immanent and necessary infinite substance whose attributes are expressed through finite modes.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> ADVAITA - ONE BRAHMAN, TWO STANDPOINTS, THREE LEVELS OF REALITY

05

STAGE 05

ADVAITA - ONE BRAHMAN, TWO STANDPOINTS, THREE LEVELS OF REALITY

ANSWER LINE

Spinoza replaces the transcendent personal creator with an impersonal, immanent and necessary infinite substance whose attributes are expressed through finite modes.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> ADVAITA - ONE BRAHMAN, TWO STANDPOINTS, THREE LEVELS OF REALITY

05

STAGE 05

ADVAITA - ONE BRAHMAN, TWO STANDPOINTS, THREE LEVELS OF REALITY

NIRGUNA BRAHMAN

SAGUNA ISVARA

SAT-CIT-ANANDA

MAYA + ADHYASA

VIVARTA != PARINAMA

ATMAN = BRAHMAN

ANIRVACANIYA: MAYA, NOT BRAHMAN

PARAMARTHIKA - ABSOLUTE

NIRGUNA BRAHMAN

- Non-dual reality beyond limiting and relational predicates.
- Sat-cit-ananda: being, consciousness and fullness - not three detachable qualities.
- Neti neti removes object-like limitations; Brahman is not a blank non-being.
- Atman-Brahman identity: liberation recognizes an always-existing identity.

VYAVAHARIKA - EMPIRICAL

SAGUNA ISVARA

- Brahman understood in relation to maya as omniscient creator, sustainer and dissolver.
- Valid object of devotion, meditation and moral governance wherever plurality is experienced.
- Jiva-Isvara distinction is religiously real at this level but ultimately sublated.
- Same Brahman, not a second deity or rival ultimate.

ONE REALITY

Same Brahman under two epistemic standpoints - not two independent Brahman.

THREE LEVELS OF REALITY

PARAMARTHIKA

Brahman alone is absolutely real.

VYAVAHARIKA

Shared world, causation, jiva and Isvara.

PRATIBHASIKA

Dream, hallucination and rope-snake error.

MAYA / ADHYASA / VIVARTA FLOW

ROPE + IGNORANCE -> SNAKE APPEARANCE -> FEAR

KNOWLEDGE -> APPEARANCE SUBLATED -> ROPE RECOGNIZED

BRAHMAN + AVIDYA -> PLURAL WORLD -> BONDAGE

JNANA -> DIFFERENCE SUBLATED -> BRAHMAN RECOGNIZED

TECHNICAL CORRECTION

TECHNICAL PRECISION: anirvacaniya (neither absolutely real nor absolutely unreal) applies to maya/avidya and the world-appearance. Do not call Brahman anirvacaniya. Brahman's ineffability concerns failed limiting predication: avacya / neti neti.

OBJECTION: Nirguna is an empty abstraction. REPLY: apophasis removes finite limits, not reality.

OBJECTION: if Brahman alone exists, who is ignorant? REPLY: ignorance belongs to the empirical jiva; its locus remains contested.

VERDICT ON THEISM: Advaita preserves religion at the path level but transcends creator-creature duality at the goal level.

TRAP

Mithya is dependent and sublatable, not sheer nothing. Maya explains apparent plurality without a real transformation of Brahman; vivarta must not be confused with parinama.

ANSWER LINE

Advaita reconciles personal religion and impersonal ultimacy by validating Saguna Isvara empirically while locating final reality in Nirguna Brahman and Atman-Brahman identity.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> VISISTADVAITA / RAMANUJA - ORGANIC UNITY OF GOD, SELVES AND WORLD

06

STAGE 06

VISISTADVAITA / RAMANUJA - ORGANIC UNITY OF GOD, SELVES AND WORLD

PERSONAL SAGUNA BRAHMAN

CIT + ACIT = GOD'S BODY

SARIRA-SARIRI

APRTHAK-SIDDHI

MATERIAL + EFFICIENT CAUSE

PARINAMA / REAL MANIFESTATION

BHAKTI + PRAPATTI

BRAHMAN / NARAYANA - SUPREME PERSONAL SAGUNA REALITY

SARIRI - INDWELLING SELF, CONTROLLER AND PURPOSE

CIT - CONSCIOUS SELVES

Real, many, morally responsible and eternally dependent jivas.

ACIT - NON-CONSCIOUS MATTER

Real, changing material order governed from within by God.

CAUSE CYCLE

SUBTLE CIT-ACIT IN BRAHMAN

causal state

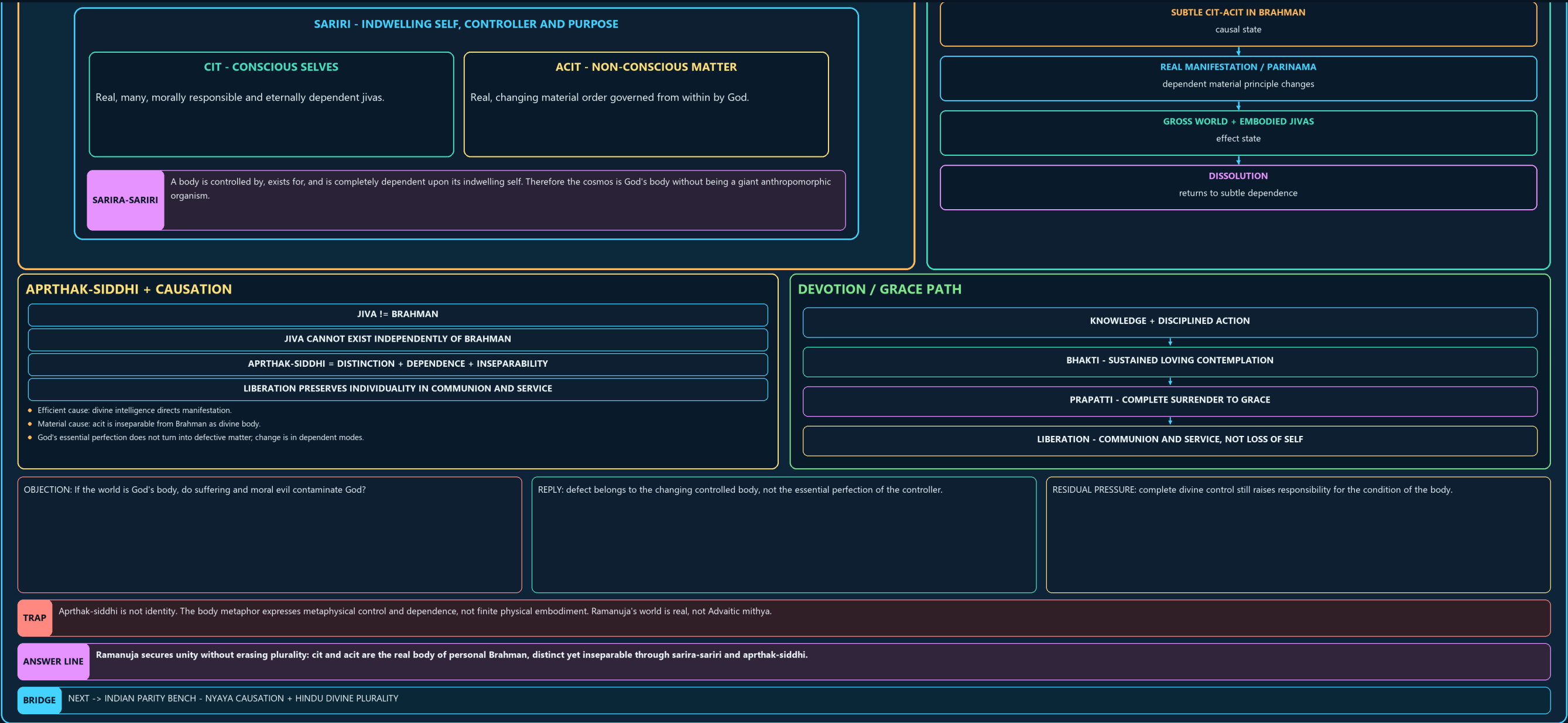
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REAL MANIFESTATION / PARINAMA

dependent material principle changes

↓

GROSS WORLD + EMBODIED JIVAS



KARMA CIRCUIT

Do not answer the nature question by merely listing proofs such as karyat and ayojanat.

HINDU DIVINE PLURALITY - TAXONOMY LADDER

POLYTHEISM
Many genuinely divine beings with distinct agencies; asks whether there are plural ultimates.

HENOTHEISM
Several gods acknowledged while one is worshipped as supreme in a context.

KATHENOTHEISM
Different deities are addressed as supreme successively - 'one god at a time'.

SECTARIAN MONOTHEISM
Vaisnava, Saiva or Sakta devotion treats one supreme deity and subordinates other forms.

UPANISADIC MONISM
One ultimate reality; unity of reality is not automatically one personal God.

VEDIC ANCHOR

RV 1.164.46 - 'ekam sad vipra bahudha vadanti': the one existent is spoken of in many ways. Use it as evidence for plural names/forms, not as an automatic proof that every Hindu school is monotheistic or monistic.

QUALIFIED VERDICT

QUALIFIED VERDICT: Hinduism is not adequately described by one label. Polytheistic practice, henotheistic/kathenotheistic invocation, sectarian monotheism and Upanisadic monism coexist. State the tradition, level and criterion of ultimacy.

TRAP

A 'nature of Nyaya God' answer must prioritize attributes, efficient causation, eternal atoms, karma and moral governance - not merely list Udayana's proofs.

ANSWER LINE

Indian parity prevents false homogenization: Nyaya preserves an efficient divine governor beside eternal atoms, while Hindu plurality ranges from many worshipped forms to one ultimate reality.

BRIDGE

NEXT -> COMPARATIVE GOD-WORLD-HUMAN RELATION MATRIX - SIX NON-EQUIVALENT GRAMMARS

08

STAGE 08

COMPARATIVE GOD-WORLD-HUMAN RELATION MATRIX - SIX NON-EQUIVALENT GRAMMARS

CREATION != IDENTITY

IDENTITY != EMBODIMENT

EMBODIMENT != APPEARANCE

APPEARANCE != ATOMIC ORDERING

SAME AXES FOR EVERY MODEL

NATURE + WORLD + HUMAN + CAUSE

CLASSICAL THEISM
CREATION / TOTAL DEPENDENCE

DEISM
CREATION + WITHDRAWAL

SPINOZA
IDENTITY / MODE-SUBSTANCE

ADVAITA
DEPENDENT APPEARANCE / IDENTITY

RAMANUJA
BODY-SOUL / INSEPARABILITY

NYAYA
EFFICIENT ARRANGEMENT / MATERIAL ATOMS

MODEL	DIVINE NATURE	GOD-WORLD	GOD-HUMAN	CAUSATION	RELIGIOUS FUNCTION / PRESSURE
CLASSICAL THEISM	Personal, necessary, omni-perfect, transcendent and immanently sustaining.	World is distinct, contingent and continuously dependent.	Creature-Creator relation; providence, prayer and moral accountability.	Creation ex nihilo; primary cause sustains secondary causes.	Strong relational worship; pressure from evil and attribute coherence.
DEISM	Personal intelligent designer, usually remote after creation.	Creates law-governed world, then rejects special intervention.	Rational dependence without continuing providence.	First institution of laws; natural order thereafter autonomous.	Fits natural regularity; weakens miracle, revelation and prayer.
SPINOZA	Impersonal, infinite, necessary substance: Deus sive Natura.	Finite things are modes in God/Nature; no external creation.	Mind and body are finite modes under Thought and Extension.	Necessary expression, not free production.	Intellectual love and rational freedom; loses personal reciprocity.
ADVAITA	Nirguna Brahman ultimately; Saguna Isvara empirically.	World is mithya through vivarta; Isvara governs empirical order.	Atman is Brahman; jiva-Isvara distinction is provisional.	Apparent manifestation without real change in Brahman.	Devotion prepares for knowledge; final theism is transcended.
RAMANUJA	Supreme personal saguna Brahman qualified by real cit and acit.	World and selves are God's real body; God indwells and exceeds them.	Jiva is distinct, dependent and inseparable; liberation preserves service.	Material and efficient cause; real manifestation / parinama.	Bhakti, prapatti and grace; pressure from evil in the divine body.
NYAYA	Personal omniscient special self within pluralist realism.	God orders eternal atoms and administers a real moral cosmos.	Distinct eternal selves receive karmic fruits through divine governance.	God efficient cause; atoms material causes.	Moral administration and Vedic authorship; karma may seem sufficient.

PHYSICAL CAUSE TEST

PHYSICAL MANIFESTATION TEST: classical theism, Advaita and Nyaya deny that an ultimate cause must be a physical object. Ramanuja's 'body' is technical dependence/control, not a finite anthropomorphic form. A cause may be known through effects without resembling them.

ULTIMATE REALITY TEST

Perfect personal agency (theism/deism/Ramanuja/Nyaya) versus impersonal infinite substance or non-dual consciousness (Spinoza/Advaita).

WORLD STATUS TEST

Distinct dependent creation | autonomous law-order | mode in substance | mithya appearance | divine body | ordered eternal atoms.

HUMAN STATUS TEST

RELIGIOUS FUNCTION TEST

STATE THE TARGET PREMISE LOGICAL POSSIBILITY TRAP REPLY AT THE SAME LEVEL KEEP THE RESIDUAL COST KNOWLEDGE != CAUSATION BODY != PHYSICAL FORM MITHYA != NON-BEING MODE != WHOLE SUBSTANCE

OBJECTION
If God cannot actualize contradictions, something lies beyond divine power.

STRONGEST REPLY
A contradiction does not name a possible object of power, maximal power ranges over genuine possibilities.

RESIDUAL COST
Descartes-style universal possibilism is an outlier that makes logic dependent on will.

OBJECTION	Infallible knowledge of A seems to close the possibility of not-A.
STRONGEST REPLY	Knowledge is not causation, timelessness, Ockhamism, Molinism and open theism deny different premises.
RESIDUAL COST	Do not claim the problem is solved until alternative possibilities or compatibilist freedom are specified.

OBJECTION	An impersonal necessary whole cannot command, forgive, answer prayer or choose creation.
STRONGEST REPLY	Personality would impose finite human categories; divine freedom is absence of external constraint.
RESIDUAL COST	Metaphysical ultimacy is retained, but worshipful reciprocity is weakened.

OBJECTION	Nirguna Brahman is empty, and maya's locus is unexplained.
STRONGEST REPLY	Apophatic negation removes limiting predicates; empirical jiva is the locus of ignorance.
RESIDUAL COST	Positive intelligibility and the locus/power of avidya remain contested.

OBJECTION	If the suffering world is God's body, evil appears to infect God.
STRONGEST REPLY	The condition of a dependent body does not transfer every defect to the controlling self.
RESIDUAL COST	Complete control still leaves a responsibility problem.

OBJECTION
If karma fixes desert and atoms supply matter, God adds no explanation.

STRONGEST REPLY
Unconscious adrista and inert atoms need intelligent ordering and distribution.

RESIDUAL COST
The move from administration to an infinite omniscient self remains debatable.

FOR: familiar causes are encountered through effects or embodied action; an utterly unmanifest cause may seem empirically idle.

AGAINST: a physical form is spatially limited, divisible and dependent. Ultimate causality requires explanatory non-dependence, not bodily manifestation.

VERDICT: embodiment may aid religious access, but it is not conceptually necessary for every ultimate cause.

TEN EXAMINER TRAPS - READ ACROSS

1. Personal does not mean anthropomorphic.	2. Transcendent does not mean spatially remote.	3. Immanent does not mean pantheistically identical.	4. Saguna and Nirguna are not two independent Brahman.	5. Anirvacaniya technically applies to maya/world appearance, not Brahman.
6. Aprthak-siddhi is inseparability, not numerical identity.	7. Nyaya God is not the material cause.	8. Monism is not automatically monotheism.	9. Process dipolarity revises classical immutability and omnipotence.	10. A graded verdict must preserve the cost of the reply.

TRAP The examiner rewards dialectic: doctrine -> target objection -> strongest reply -> residual cost. A reply that merely repeats the doctrine earns little.

ANSWER LINE No model escapes cost: each protects one dimension of ultimacy by revising another, so the best conclusion is comparative and graded rather than triumphalist.

BRIDGE NEXT -> PYQ ROUTING, ANSWER SPINES AND MODEL PHILOSOPHICAL CONCLUSION

10

STAGE 10 PYQ ROUTING, ANSWER SPINES AND MODEL PHILOSOPHICAL CONCLUSION

13 VERIFIED OWNER PYQS: 2018-2024 DEFINE BEFORE EVALUATING CONSTANT COMPARISON AXES OBJECTION -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL 10 / 15 / 20 MARK SPINES DIRECTIVE FIDELITY GRADED VERDICT

YEAR / MARKS	VERIFIED ASK	NON-NEGOTIABLE ROUTE
2018 - 10	Is Hinduism poly-theistic?	Criterion of plurality -> polytheism / henotheism / kathenotheism -> RV 1.164.46 -> qualified verdict.
2019 - 15	Personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God.	Define axes -> classical theism / Spinoza -> Saguna / Nirguna -> strengths, pressures and synthesis.
2019 - 15	Man-God relation in any one religion in India.	Choose one complete system -> nature -> world -> self -> bondage/liberation -> critical assessment.
2020 - 10	Freedom of will and an omnipotent God.	Define power/freedom -> self-restraint -> foreknowledge premises -> named solution -> cost.
2020 - 20	Nature of God in Hinduism with special reference to Visistadvaita.	Personal Brahman -> cit-acit body -> aprthak-siddhi -> causation -> bhakti/prapatti -> defect objection.
2021 - 10	Nature of God in Nyaya philosophy.	Pluralist realism -> special self -> efficient cause / material atoms -> adrista -> objection/reply.
2022 - 10	Spinoza's notion of God and His attributes.	Deus sive Natura -> one substance -> attributes/modes -> necessity -> personality objection.
2022 - 15	Relation between God and Self according to Ramanuja.	Sarira-sariri -> aprthak-siddhi -> difference + dependence -> liberation preserves individuality.
2022 - 15	Sankara's Brahman and whether it leaves room for theism.	Nirguna / Saguna -> sat-cit-ananda -> maya/vivarta -> two levels -> provisional theism verdict.
2023 - 10	Elucidate personalistic and impersonalistic aspects.	Clarify contrast -> Western and Indian pairs -> reconciliation device -> exact concluding distinction.
2023 - 15	How is God both immanent and transcendent in theism?	Ontological definitions -> classical sustaining cause -> Ramanuja contrast -> one-sided dangers.
2024 - 15	Spinoza's God embedded in substance and attributes.	Substance argument -> Thought/Extension -> modes -> Natura naturans/naturata -> critical verdict.
2024 - 15	Must ultimate cause have physical manifestation?	Distinguish embodiment / manifestation / causation -> strongest for and against -> comparative verdict.

10 MARKS Define exact contrast -> 2 doctrines -> one discriminating relation -> one objection/reply -> direct verdict.	15 MARKS Frame problem -> reconstruct doctrine/presupposition -> canonical example -> nearest rival -> objection/reply -> graded verdict.	20 MARKS Classify God-concept -> full metaphysics -> world + human relations -> Indian-Western comparison -> two dialectics -> surviving notion of ultimacy.
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ELUCIDATE clarify a distinction precisely	DISCUSS balanced exposition plus stated position	CRITICALLY EXAMINE reconstruct, object, reply and assess	DO YOU AGREE? announce criterion, test both sides, decide
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MODEL PHILOSOPHICAL CONCLUSION	MODEL CONCLUSION: The notion of God is not one universal concept but a family of metaphysical models. Classical theism preserves perfect agency and transcendence; Spinoza secures unity and necessity; Advaita protects non-dual absoluteness; Ramanuja reconciles unity with real plurality; and Nyaya preserves intelligent causation and moral governance. Their adequacy depends on whether ultimacy is understood primarily as perfect agency, infinite substance, non-dual consciousness, organic unity or intelligent ordering.
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TRAP Do not write a generic theology essay. Name the model, state its God-world-human grammar, use the exact technical relation, test one objection, and answer the printed directive.

ANSWER LINE A high-scoring answer moves from definition to metaphysical mechanism, then to relation, objection, reply and a qualified comparative verdict.

BRIDGE END OF MASTER -> Use Stage 10 to route the exact printed demand.